The Virtual Illusion: Or the Automatic Writing of the World

Jean Baudrillard

There is always a camera hidden somewhere. It may be a real one – we may be filmed without knowing it. We may also be invited to replay our own life in whatever television network. Anyway, *the virtual camera is in our head*, and our whole life has taken on a video dimension. We might believe that we exist in the original, but today this original has become an exceptional version for the happy few. Our own reality doesn't exist anymore. We are exposed to the instantaneous retransmission of all our facts and gestures on whatever channel. We would have experienced this before as police control. Today it is just like an advertising promotion.

Then it is irrelevant to get upset with talk shows or reality shows, and to criticize them as such. For they are only a spectacular version, and so an innocent one, of the transformation of life itself, of everyday life, into virtual reality. We just don't need the media to reflect our problems in real time – *each existence is telepresent to itself*. TV and the media have left their mediatized space to invest 'real' life from the inside and to substitute themselves to it exactly as a virus does in a normal cell.

We don't need digital gloves or a digital suit. As we are, we are moving around in the world as in a synthesized image. We have swallowed our microphones and headsets, producing intense interference effects, due to the short-circuiting of life and its technical diffusion. We have interiorized our own prosthetic image and become the professional showmen of our own lives. Compared with this, the reality shows are only side-effects and, moreover, mystifying, because in indicting them as manipulation, the critics assume that there is somewhere an original form of life, and reality shows would be only the parody and the simulation of it (Disneyland).

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This criticism is over, as is over every art of situationistic criticism of the 'spectacle' and the concept of 'spectacle', as also in substance all criticism of 'alienation'. Unfortunately, I would say. Because the human abstraction of the spectacle was never hopeless, it was always a chance for de-alienation. Whereas the operation of the world in real time, its unconditional realization is really without alternative. Radicality has changed, and all negative criticism, surviving itself, actually helps its object to survive. For instance, the critic of religion and of its official manifestation misses the fact that religion is practically much more realized in many other forms, irreligious, profane, political or cultural forms, where it is no longer recognizable as such. It is the same thing with virtuality. Direct criticism in terms of new techniques, new images, masks the fact that its concept has been distilled everywhere throughout real life, in homeopathic doses, no longer detectable. And if the rate of reality is lower from day to day, it is because the medium itself has passed into life, and become a common ritual of transparency. Same thing for virtuality: all this digital, numerical and electronic equipment is only the epiphenomenon of the virtualization of human beings in their core. If this can overwhelm people's fantasy to such a degree, it is because we are already, not in some other world, but in this very life, in a state of photosynthesis. If we can today produce a virtual clone of Richard Bohringer to put it on stage in his place, then because he has already replicated himself, he has already become his own clone before they clone him.

But anyway, the reality show can be used as a micro-model for the analysis of all virtual reality. Be it the immediacy of the information on all screens, the telepresence, or the presence on the TV, in all the televisual actings and happenings, it is always the question of 'real time', of the collapse of the real and its double. Live your life in real time (live and die directly on the screen). Think in real time (your thinking is immediately transferred on to the printer). Make your revolution in real time (not in the street, but in the broadcasting studio). Live your love and passion in real time (by videotaping each other as it runs). This conversion of the mediatized into the immediatized, that is into an immediate catalytic operation of the real by the screen, this immediatic revolution is already implied in McLuhan's formula 'The Medium is the Message', which has never been analysed in its full consequences. McLuhan remains the prophetic theoritician of this collapse of the medium and the message, and thus in some way the prophet of the vanishing

process of information and communication (whose assumption he emphasized at the same time!). 'The Medium is the Message' stays as the Mene Tekel Epharsim of the communication era, its password and the sign of its end.

But there is another predecessor for all technologies of the Virtual: it is the ready-made. Again, for example, the reality show: all those human beings, literally extracted from their real life to play out their AIDS or conjugal psychodrama on the TV screen have their prototype in the bottleholder of Duchamp. The artist distracted the bottleholder from the real world in the same way, displaced it on another level to confer on it an undefinable hyper-reality. A paradoxical acting-out, putting an end both to the bottle-holder as a real object and to art as the invention of another scene, and to the artist as the protagonist of another world. To all aesthetic idealization, Duchamp opposes a violent desublimation of art and of the real by their instantaneous short-circuit. Extremization of the two forms: the bottleholder, extracted from its context, from its idea, from its function, becomes more real than the real (hyperreal) and more art than art (it enters into the transaesthetics of banality, of insignificance, of nullity, where today the pure and indifferent form of art is to be seen).

Any object, any individual, any situation today could be a virtual ready-made, as it could be said of them all what Duchamp implicitly means about his ready-made object: 'It exists, I met it!' This is the only label for existence. Graffiti – another form of ready-made – don't say anything else: 'I exist, here I am, my name is so and so'. The pure and minimal form of identity: I exist, I met myself. The ready-made always seems like these stuffed animals, vitrified as if they were alive, hypnotized in the pure form of appearance – 'naturalized'. But I would say that today art in general also looks like a naturalized species, vitrified in its pure formal essence.

Duchamp's coup has been repeated since then indefinitely, not only in the field of art, but in all individual and social functions, especially in the mediasphere. The last phase being precisely the reality show, where everybody is invited to present himself as he is, key in hand, and to play his live show on the screen (with the obscene connotation of it), just as the ready-made object comes to play its hyperrealistic role on the screen of the museum.

All these mediatic events relate to this crucial phase in the world of information and communication – which phase art, politics and production have known before. The drama of the mediatic class

is that it is starving on the other side of the screen, in front of an indifferent consuming mass, in front of the teleabsence of the masses. Any form of telepresence will be good enough to exorcize this teleabsence. Just as it was a vital necessity for capital to have workers and producers transformed into active consumers, and even into direct stockholders in the capitalist economy (this doesn't change anything in the business, the strategy being, as always, to remove the tablecloth without changing the organization of the table), thus the telespectator has to be transferred not in front of the screen where he is staying anyway, passively escaping his responsibility as citizen, but into the screen, on the other side of the screen — in short, to operate with him the same conversion as Duchamp with his bottleholder, transferring it as it was on the other side of art and thus creating a definitive ambiguity between art and the real world. Today art is nothing more than this paradoxical confusion between both. And information, too, is nothing more than the paradoxical confusion between the event and the medium, including all forms of intoxication and mystification connected to it.

So we have all become ready-mades. Objects transposed to the other side of the screen, mediumnized (we don't even enjoy the good old status of passive spectator anymore), hypostasized like these people transfigured in situ, on the spot, by aesthetic or mediatic decision, transfigured in their specific habits and ways of life, in living museal pieces. Cloned to our own image by high definition, and dedicated by involution into our own image to mediatic stupefaction, just as the ready-made is dedicated to aesthetic stupefaction. And just as Duchamp's acting-out opens on an overall aestheticization, where any piece of junk will be promoted to a piece of art, and respectively any piece of art demoted to a piece of junk — so this immediatic conversion opens on a universal virtuality, which means the radical achievement of the reality through its acting-out in real time.

All cultural spaces are involved. For example some new museums in a sort of Disneyland processing, try to bring people not in front of the painting, which is not interactive enough, and even suspect as pure spectacular consumption, but into the painting. By insinuating them audio-visually into the virtual reality of the *Déjeuner sur le Herbe*, people will enjoy it in real time, feeling and tasting the whole Impressionist context, and eventually interacting with the picture. Well, the masses usually prefer the passive roles,

and keep away from representation. This must change, and they must be invested as interactive partners. No question of free speaking or free acting – just break their resistance and destroy their immunities.

It is a question of life and death. When the indifference of the masses becomes dangerous for the political or cultural class, then interactive strategies must be invented to extort a response at any price. In fact, the interactive mass is still a mass, with all characteristics of a mass, simply reflecting itself on both sides of the screen. But the screen is not a mirror, and, while it was some kind of magic to pass beyond the mirror, there is no magic at all in passing beyond the screen. It's impossible anyway – there is no other side of the screen. No depth – just a surface. No hidden face – just an interface.

Besides, the masses were not without an answer. Their answer was silence, the silence of the silent majorities. This challenge of silence is now cancelled, when people are forced to ask their own questions, when they are assigned to speech. If they had some questions, these will never be autonomous, they surely will be programmed in the schedule. But this implication *'en trompe l'oeil'* doesn't even save the media and the information from their inertia, from their proliferating fatal inertia. Mass media or micro-media, directive or interactive, the chain reaction of the images is the same. It is simply materialized in real time and in everybody's head.

Now what is exactly at stake in this hegemonic trend to Virtuality? What is the idea of the Virtual? It seems that it would be the radical effectuation, the unconditional realization of the world, the transformation of all our acts, of all historical events, of all material substance and energy into pure information. The ideal would be the resolution of the world by the actualization of all facts and data.

This is the theme of Arthur Clarke's fable about the names of God. The monks of Tibet are devoting themselves to the fastidious work of transcribing the 99 billion names of God, after which the world will be accomplished, and it will be the end. Exhausted by this everlasting spelling of the names of God, they call IBM people, computer experts who fulfil the work in a few months. A perfect allegory of the achievement of the world in real time by the operation of the virtual. Unfortunately this is also the end of the world in real time. For with this virtual countdown of the names of God the great promise of the end was realized, and the technicians of

IBM, who left the site after work (and didn't believe of course in the prophecy) saw the stars in the sky fading and vanishing one by one.

Maybe it is an allegory of our technical transfiguration of the world: its accelerated end, its anticipated resolution – the final score of modern millenarianism, but without hope of salvation, revelation or even apocalypse. Simply accelerating the process of declining (in the double sense of the word), towards a pure and simple disappearance. The human species would be invested, without knowing it, with the task of programming, by exhausting all its possibilities, the code *for the automatic disappearance of the world*. This is the very idea of Virtuality. Rather than the ideal transformation of the world, the hidden finality of the technique would be that of building a perfectly autonomous world, from which we can retire and remove definitively. In order to step out of it, the world must be achieved. As long as we stay here as alien beings, the world cannot be perfect. And to be perfect it must be constructed and artificial. Because there is no perfection in the natural state. The human being itself is a dangerous imperfection. If he wants to achieve this sort of immortality, he must also treat himself as an artefact, and get out of himself, in order to move on an artificial orbit, where he can revolve eternally.

We all dream of an *ex nihilo* creation, of a world emerging and moving without our intervention, we dream of perfect autonomous beings who, far from acting against our will as in the fable (the Sorcerer's apprentice?), would meet our desire to escape our own will, and realize the world as a self-fulfilling prophecy. So we dream of perfect computers, of autoprogramming Artificial Intelligence. But if we allow artificial beings to become intelligent, and even more intelligent than us, we don't allow them to have their own will. We don't allow them what God finally allowed to us – the intelligence of Evil. We cannot bear a real challenge from another species, and if we concede intelligence to other beings, then this intelligence must still be the manifestation of our desire. If God permitted us to raise some questions about our own liberty, we don't allow those beings to raise such questions about themselves. No liberty, no will, no desire, no sexuality. We want them complex, creative, interactive, but without spirit. By the way, it seems that these 'intelligent' machines have found, if not the way to transgression and freedom, at least the by-ways to accident and catastrophe. It seems that they have an evil genius for dysfunctions, electronic viruses and other

perverse effects, which save them, and us in the same way, from perfection and from reaching the end of their possibilities.

The perfect crime would be to build a world-machine without defect and to leave it without traces. But it never succeeds. We leave traces overall – viruses, lapsus, germs, catastrophes – signs of defect, of imperfection, which are like man's signature in the heart of an artificial world.

All forms of High Technology illustrate the fact that behind his doubles and his prostheses, his biological clones and his virtual images, the human being is secretly fomenting his disappearance. For example, the video recorder, connected with the TV: it sees the film in your place. If it hadn't been for this technical possibility of devolution, of a vicarious accomplishment, we would have felt obliged to see it. For we always feel a little responsible for films we haven't seen, for desires we haven't realized, for people we haven't answered, for crimes we haven't committed, for money we haven't spent. All this generates a mass of removed possibilities, and the idea that a machine is there that can deal with these possibilities, can stock them, filter them (an answer machine, a memory bank), and progressively absorb and reabsorb them, is a very comforting idea. All these machines can be called virtual, since they are the medium of virtual pleasure, the abstract pleasure of the image, which is often good enough for our happiness. Most of these machines are used for delusion, for eluding communication ('Leave a message . . .'), for absolving us of the face-to-face relation and the social responsibility. They don't really lead to action, they substitute for it most of the time. So with the film on the video recorder: maybe I'll see this film later, but maybe I'll not do it at all. Am I sure I really want to see it anyway? But the machine must work. Thus the consumption of the machine converges with the consumption of the desire.

All these machines are wonderful. They give us a sort of freedom. They help us to get free from the machine itself, since they interconnect one with another and function in a loop. They help us to get free from our own will and from our own production. What a relief to see all at once 20 pages erased by a caprice of the word-processor (or by an error of the user, which comes to the same thing). They never would have such a value if they hadn't had the chance to disappear! What the computer gives to you, too easily perhaps, it takes it away quite as easily. Everything is in order. Technological equation to zero. It is always the talk about

negative perverse effects. Here the technique assumes a positive (homeopathic) perverse effect. The integrated circuit reverses itself, performing in some way *the automatic writing of the world.*

Now let us consider some different aspects of this virtual achievement, of this automatic writing of the world: High Definition; High Fidelity; Real Time; the Genetic Code; Artificial Intelligence.

In *High Definition*, the (electronic, numerical or synthesized) image is nothing more than the emanation of the digital code that generated it. It has nothing more to do with representation, and even less with aesthetic illusion. All illusion is abolished by technical perfection. So with the three-dimensional image: it is a pure disillusion, since the magic of the image is just to substract one dimension from the real world. In the hologram, this perfection of the virtual image, all parts are microscopically identical to the whole, so we are in a fractal deconstruction of the image, which is supplanted by its pure luminous definition.

High Fidelity. Disappearance of the music by excess of fidelity, by the promiscuity of the music and its absolute technical model. Holographic music, holophonic, stereophonic, as if it had swallowed its own genetic code and rejected it as an artificial synthesis – clinical music, sterile, expurgated of all noise.

Real Time. The equivalent of High Definition for the image. Simultaneity of the event and its diffusion in the information sphere. Instant proximity of man and his actions at a distance. Telepresence: you can manage your business in situ at the other end of the world, by the medium of your electronic clone. Just like the space of the image in High Definition, each moment in Real Time is microscopically coded, microscopically isolated, in a closed and integrated circuit. As in the hologram, each parcel of time concentrates the total information relative to the event, as if we could control the event from all sides at once. No distance, no memory, no continuity, no death: the extreme 'reality of time' is in fact its extreme virtuality. All the suspense, all the imprevisibility of time is over.

Genetic Coding. What is at stake here is the simulation of a perfect human being, of a body of high definition, through the controlled engineering and dispatching of the genome. Making up of a virtual body much better performing than the original – plastic genetic surgery. The genetic code itself, the DNA, which concentrates the whole definition of any living being in a minimal space and a minimal formula, is the ideal type of virtuality.

Last, but not least: *Artificial Intelligence.* Something like an

artifical brain-recording, adapted to an equally artificial environment. Thinking quite immediately inscribed on the screen, in direct interaction with the data, the software, the memories – intelligence in real time. Thinking becomes a high definition operation, suppressing all distance, all ambiguity, all enigmatic eventualities, suppressing the very illusion of thought. Just as the illusion of the image disappears into its virtual reality, just as the illusion of the body disappears into its genetic inscription, just as the illusion of the world disappears into its technical artefacts, so the natural intelligence of the world disappears into its Artificial Intelligence. Not any trace in all this of the world as a game, as a fake, as a machination, as a crime, and not as a logical mechanism, or a reflex cybernetic machine, with the human brain as mirror and model.

Seriously, Artificial Intelligence is everything except artificial. It is definitive 'realthinking' (like we say 'Realpolitik'), fully materialized by the interaction of all virtualities of analysis and computing. We could even say that Artificial Intelligence goes beyond itself through a too high definition of the real, through a delirious sophistication of data and operations – but this is only the consequence of the fact that Artificial Intelligence is a matter of hyperrealization of thinking, of the objective processing of thinking.

Not the slightest feeling in all this of illusion, of artifice, of seduction, of a more subtle game of thought. For thought is not a mechanism of higher functions, nor a range of operational reflexes. It is a rhetoric of forms, of moving illusions and appearances. It reacts positively to the illusion of the world, and negatively to its reality, it plays off the appearances against the reality, turning the illusion of the world against the world itself. The thinking machine masters only the computing process. It doesn't rule over the apppearances, and its function, as well as all other cybernetic and virtual machines, is to destroy this essential illusion by counterfeiting the world in real time.

All these aspects we spoke about curiously rely on paradoxes. 'Real Time' is in fact a purely virtual time. 'Artificial Intelligence' is nothing like artificial. 'Virtual Reality' is at the antipodes of the real world. As for 'High Definition', it is quite antiphrastically the synonym of 'high dilution'. The high definition of the medium corresponds to the lowest definition of the message. The highest definition of the information corresponds to the lowest definition of the event. The highest definition of sex (in porn) corresponds to the lowest definition of desire. The highest definition of the language

(in its numerical forms, in the new computing) corresponds to the lowest definition of sense. The highest definition of the Other (in interaction and communication) corresponds to the lowest definition of exchange and alterity. Everywhere high definition corresponds to a world where referential substance is scarcely to be found anymore.

Such are the stakes involved in the virtual realization of the world. And we must take it as irreversible. The logic of this leads to the end, to the final solution, or resolution. Once performed, it would be the equivalent of a perfect crime. While the other crime, the 'original' crime is never perfect, and always leaves traces – we as living and mortal beings are a living trace of this criminal imperfection – the future extermination, which would be the result from the absolute determination of the world and of its elements, would leave no traces at all. We would not even have the choice, nor a chance to die, to really die. We would have been kidnapped and desintegrated in real time and virtual reality long before the stars go out.

All this Artificial Intelligence, telesensoriality, Virtual Reality and so on, this is the end of illusion. The illusion of the world – not its analytical countdown – the wild illusion of passion, of thinking, the aesthetic illusion of the scene, the psychic and moral illusion of the Other, of Good and Evil (of Evil especially perhaps), of True and False, the wild illusion of Death, or living at any price – all this is made volatile in psychosensorial telereality, in all these sophisticated technologies which transfer us to the virtual, to the contrary of illusion: to radical disillusion.

Fortunately, all this is impossible. High Definition is 'virtually' unrealizable, in its attempt to produce images, sounds, information, bodies in microvision, in stereoscopy, as you have never seen them, as you will never see them. Unrealizable also is the fantasy of Artificial Intelligence. It is too intelligent, too performing to be true – this brain-becoming of the world, this world-becoming of the brain, as it has never functioned, without a body, autonomized, inhuman – a brain of high definition outlining a universe of high definition Something like an ethical and technical purification. It will never succeed, fortunately. Not that we trust in human nature or in a future enlightenment, but because there is actually no place for both natural and artificial intelligence. There is no place both for the illusion of the world and for a virtual programmation of the world. There is no place both for the world and for its double.

When the virtual operation of the world is finished, when all the

names of God have been spelt out – which is the same basic fantasy as the declination of the human genome or the world-wide declination of all data and information – then we too shall see the stars fading away.

Jean Baudrillard is author of numerous books, many of them translated into English, the most recent of which include: *Symbolic Exchange and Death* (Sage, 1993), *The Transparency of Evil* (1993), *The Illusion of the End* (1994), *Simulacra and Simulation* (1994).